2

CONFLICT

“War is a bad and contemptible thing, but people at war are sometimes better than in everyday life.”

Ze’ev Jabotinsky

In the summer the hills around Nablus are parched and barren, almost a moonscape; in the winter they are cold, damp, windswept. The homes built atop them enjoy stunning views, but they are modest properties, without the swimming pools or stone patios found in some of the larger and wealthier Israeli settlements. Infrastructure is modest—narrow streets lined with beat-up minivans. There are no nearby Israeli cities for shopping or entertainment. Jerusalem is 50 kilometers down a winding two-lane highway that is often clogged with traffic. Even if you set aside the political and ideological problems with living there, Israel boasts far nicer places to raise a family.

But of course ideology is precisely the point. Austere settlements have taken root on the hilltops in almost every direction around Nablus: Eli to the south; Kedumim to the west; Elon Moreh to the east. The families who live here are mostly religious, drawn by the area’s prominent role in the Old Testament. Shiloh, for example, was the focal point of Jewish worship before the First Temple was built in Jerusalem.

In recent years these settlements have gained notoriety for something else: the regular acts of violence and arson their inhabitants commit against the nearby Palestinian villages. They are known (in both English and Hebrew) as “price tag” attacks, because they are meant to extract a “price” for Israeli or Palestinian actions against the settler movement. Such causal logic seems irrelevant in an era of right-wing rule. Benjamin Netanyahu is hardly an enemy of the settlers, even if his role as a supporter is often exaggerated. Still, the attacks continue. The settlers often dismiss them as